

Core physical examination: a three-way crosswalk

Gowda 2014 (national consensus, clerkship inpatient) · Jewett 2024 (preclinical ambulatory) · ISMMS (preclerkship). Uchida 2014 named the Core + Cluster model but does not publish a maneuver list.

Area	Gowda 2014 — 37 maneuvers	Jewett 2024 — 15	ISMMS — 24
General	• General appearance • Level of consciousness • Orientation • Temperature (record) • Weight/height/BMI (record)	• In distress / no distress • “Sick / not sick” appearance	• Observes general appearance • Assesses orientation (person, place, time)
Vital signs	• Blood pressure • Heart rate • Respiratory rate	—	• Measures blood pressure • Measures heart rate (pulse) • Measures respiratory rate
HEENT	• External inspection of eye and lid • Pupillary reaction to light • Inspection of oropharynx and dentition	• Eye inspection / pupillary light reflex • Oropharynx inspection	• Inspects external eye and lid • Assesses pupillary light reflex (CN II/III) • Inspects oropharynx and dentition
Neck	• Lymph node palpation (cervical, supraclavicular, axillary) • <i>Thyroid palpation → cluster</i>	• Palpation for lymphadenopathy	• Palpates cervical lymph nodes
Chest / pulmonary	• Thorax inspection • Chest auscultation anterior and posterior • Chest percussion posteriorly	• Pulmonary auscultation (6 posterior, 1 axillary, 1 apex bilaterally)	• Percusses posterior chest (3 levels) • Auscultates posterior chest (3 levels) • Auscultates anterior chest (2 levels)
Cardiac	• <i>Carotid artery palpation → cluster</i> • <i>Jugular venous pulse → cluster</i> • Cardiac point of maximal impulse • Cardiac auscultation, diaphragm, six areas • <i>Cardiac auscultation, bell at apex → cluster</i>	• Cardiac auscultation (4 areas, diaphragm and bell)	• Palpates chest for point of maximal impulse (PMI) • Auscultates heart in 4 areas
Abdomen	• Abdominal inspection • Abdominal auscultation • Abdominal palpation in six areas • <i>Liver palpation → cluster</i> • Lymph node palpation (inguinal)	• Inspection • Palpation (superficial and deep)	• Inspects abdomen • Auscultates abdomen before palpation • Light abdominal palpation (4 quadrants) • Deep abdominal palpation (4 quadrants)
Vascular	• Posterior tibial or dorsalis pedis palpation • Lower extremities for edema, bilaterally	• Dorsalis pedis and posterior tibial pulses bilaterally • Palpation for edema bilaterally	• Palpates posterior tibial pulses (bilateral) • Palpates dorsalis pedis pulses (bilateral) • Palpates lower extremity for edema
Skin, extremities, MSK	• Skin inspection • Inspection of extremities • Inspection of joints • Inspection of limbs for alignment and symmetry	—	• Folded into general appearance
Neurologic	• Assessment of speech • Cranial nerves • Motor exam, upper and lower extremities • <i>Deep tendon reflexes (biceps, patellar) → cluster</i> • <i>Sensory exam (light touch / pinprick) → cluster</i> • Gait	• Gross UE flexion and extension against resistance • Hip flexion against resistance • Gait	• Gross UE motor strength (≥2 groups each arm) • Gross LE motor strength (≥2 groups each leg) • Assesses gait

Magenta → cluster = in Gowda's core, placed in an ISMMS cluster and performed when the presenting problem indicates it.

All three counts are examination maneuvers only. Hand hygiene and draping are excluded from every column; ISMMS counts them as 3 universal items alongside the 24.

Jewett 2024 and ISMMS side by side

Both adapt Gowda for preclinical learners. Jewett's setting is the ambulatory well-patient visit; ours is an early clinical skills course.

In ISMMS, not in Jewett	In Jewett, not in ISMMS
● Vital signs — the whole section Blood pressure · heart rate · respiratory rate. Jewett's core has no vital signs at all. ● Orientation to person, place, time Jewett keeps "sick / not sick" appearance only. ● Percusses posterior chest Jewett auscultates but does not percuss. ● Auscultates abdomen before palpation Jewett inspects and palpates only. ● Palpates chest for PMI Jewett auscultates the heart but does not palpate for the PMI. ● Light and deep palpation as two items Jewett scores them as one.	● Nothing that we drop outright Every Jewett item appears in our core, either directly or inside a broader item. ● "Sick / not sick" appearance Folded into our "observes general appearance." ● Hip flexion against resistance Covered by our "LE motor strength, ≥2 groups each leg." ● Forearm flexion and extension Covered by our "UE motor strength, ≥2 groups each arm."

The difference in one line

Jewett's core is a subset of ours. We add vital signs, orientation, chest percussion, abdominal auscultation, and PMI palpation — the difference between a well-patient screening exam and one built to carry a presenting problem.

A note on Jewett's count

The paper reports a 15-item core (5 high-agreement items plus 10 added by focus group), but Table 1 lists 14 maneuvers and the narrative names 8 additions rather than 10. Cite the figure as "approximately 15", or cite Table 1 directly.